Team 25: What Explains the Rise of Indian Chess?

An Analysis of FIDE Rating Lists, 2001–Present

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Open Project – Proposal

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1 Main Hypothesis / Question

Over two decades, India has gone from one globally recognised chess star to a deep bench of elite players. The 2022 Chess Olympiad was held in Chennai, and in December 2024 D. Gukesh became world champion. This is widely reported as a "chess boom", but headlines are not evidence. Several stories fit the same picture: a gradual build-up over many years, a sudden jump after online chess grew during the COVID-19 lockdowns, or simply more Indians being rated by FIDE at all.

Central question: *Is the growth in India's high-rated and titled players a steady long-term trend, or did it accelerate after specific events, and is it unusual compared with other federations?* Our working hypothesis is that the rise is mostly a long-running trend, with at most a modest post-2020 acceleration that is partly shared by other federations. We split the question into three parts.

1. **Pool or strength?** Is the rise explained by a larger pool of rated Indian players, or by a higher *share* of strong players in it?
2. **Timing.** Does the timing fit a post-2020 (online chess) effect better than a trend already under way?
3. **Comparison.** Is India unusual, or do other federations show similar growth (e.g. from rating inflation or more rated events)?

We will build measures of both the *size* and the *strength* of the group, compare trends before and after key events, use other federations as benchmarks, and test the competing explanations with appropriate statistics, reporting uncertainty. We will avoid causal claims the data cannot support, and note the main threats: rating inflation and rule changes, participation versus true strength, survivorship (inactive players dropping off later lists), and inconsistent list formats across years.

(a) Source papers, blogs, podcasts

[1] FIDE. *FIDE Ratings: Download Rating Lists.* `https://ratings.fide.com/download_lists.phtml`.
[2] Elo, A. E. (1978). *The Rating of Chessplayers, Past and Present.* Arco Publishing.
[3] Olimpbase. *History of Elo Ratings 1971–2001.* `https://olimpbase.org/Elo/summary.html`.

(b) Languages and tools

Python (`pandas`, `scipy.stats`, `matplotlib`/Plotly), Git/GitHub for version control.

(c) Datasets

Monthly FIDE rating lists (2001 onwards, roughly a million players per list; fields: FIDE ID, federation, title, rating, birth year, sex) from `ratings.fide.com`. Primary group: federation IND; a few comparison federations to be chosen during exploration. The data are public rating records; we report only aggregate trends, and will state FIDE's usage terms and cite all sources in the final report.

(d) LLM links

2 Logistics

(a) Updated spreadsheet

https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1tvUrJxv8OnBDu2KosB9XRdEo8XhPkGPStZWP895Ao9

Milestones: Checkpoint 1 (21 Oct): repository, download/parse scripts (January lists first), IND filter, exploratory plots. Checkpoint 2 (4 Nov): comparisons, event analysis, final charts, report, 3–5 minute video, references and reflection note. **Working mode:** a shared GitHub repository with pull requests and a weekly sync-up, plus the Friday help-session slots; in-person meetings at the Dept. Library as needed. Everyone reviews each other's code.